

ALBERTA DISABILITY INCOME REFORM SERIES

Document 9 of the AISH/ADAP Policy Analysis Series

THE INTERGENERATIONAL CONTRADICTION

How ADAP Guarantees the Dependency It Claims to Prevent

April 2026

Section 1: The Policy Premise

ADAP — the Alberta Disability Assistance Program — is the provincial government's replacement for AISH, effective July 1, 2026. Its stated premise is that disability income support should be designed to encourage and facilitate movement toward employment and greater independence. The framework assumes that with appropriate employment supports, skills building, and financial incentives, a meaningful portion of disabled Albertans can reduce their reliance on government assistance over time.

This premise is not inherently unreasonable as applied to some recipients. But it rests on a foundation the government has simultaneously dismantled: the systems that produce independent, functional disabled adults do not begin at age 18. They begin at birth.

THE CORE ARGUMENT

ADAP is premised on the idea that the current generation of disabled adults can move toward independence.

The same government is simultaneously failing every upstream system — education, children's disability services, pediatric healthcare — that would give the next generation of disabled children any realistic pathway to independence.

The government cannot claim to be building toward independence while guaranteeing dependency in the next generation through documented, systemic failure.

Section 2: Three Children — One Household — One Contradiction

The following profiles are drawn from the documented circumstances of three children in a single household in Alberta. All three share a confirmed rare chromosomal syndrome. All three carry an ASD Level 3 diagnosis — the most severe classification under the DSM-5. Their profiles are presented without identifying information. They are not hypothetical. They are documented.

CHILD PROFILE 1 — The Child the System Has Already Determined Cannot Work

DOCUMENTED PROFILE

- Rare chromosomal syndrome with confirmed genetic documentation.
- ASD Level 3 — requiring substantial support across all settings.
- Non-verbal or minimally verbal communication.
- Active behavioural profile: aggression, flight risk, crisis presentations.
- Cannot be safely supported by substitute educational staff — documented in writing by the school.
- Requires one-on-one funded support worker for school attendance.
- Has never attended school without specialized one-on-one support.

POLICY CONTRADICTION

- ADAP is premised on a pathway to employment. This child has no such pathway — not through lack of effort, not through lack of supports, but because the severity of documented disability makes independent, sustained employment functionally impossible.
- The government has, through the school's own documentation, already acknowledged this child cannot be safely managed without specialized individual support. It has simultaneously designed an adult income program that assumes employment is the goal.
- When this child turns 18, ADAP — or whatever replaces it — will be the program they are assessed against. The same framework being applied to their parent today will be applied to them. The same income reduction. The same removal of appeal rights. The same employment-first premise.
- The government is not building toward independence for this child. It is deferring the bill.

CHILD PROFILE 2 — The Child the System Has Written Off as a Problem for Later

DOCUMENTED PROFILE

- Rare chromosomal syndrome with confirmed genetic documentation.
- ASD Level 3 — requiring substantial support across all settings.
- School has acknowledged in writing that no substitute educational assistant can safely provide support.
- When his EA is unavailable, he cannot attend school. This occurs without advance notice.
- A school meeting documented that guest EA support was the operative plan — four days before the same school argued in writing that no guest EA could safely support him.
- Active ATPC complaint: 7 grounds, 32-entry evidence index. Filed against the school principal.

- Accountability gaps at the school level are documented, timestamped, and unresolved.

POLICY CONTRADICTION

- The school system has not built a sustainable support framework for this child. It has managed him reactively and inconsistently, produced contradictory written positions about his needs, and left accountability gaps that required a formal complaint process to address.
- This is not a child being supported toward future independence. This is a child being managed in the short term while the question of his long-term trajectory is deferred.
- The government has no mechanism to hold the school accountable for the downstream cost of that deferral. If this child reaches adulthood without adequate educational foundation or transition planning, he becomes a more dependent adult — not a more independent one.
- ADAP assumes that employment supports can bridge the gap between disability and independence. They cannot bridge a gap that the educational system spent a decade widening.

CHILD PROFILE 3 — The Child Whose Documented Needs Are Being Actively Reframed

DOCUMENTED PROFILE

- Rare chromosomal syndrome with confirmed genetic documentation.
- ASD Level 3 — requiring substantial support across all settings.
- Active cardiac monitoring protocol with a 911 directive in place at school.
- If she presents with cardiac symptoms at school, her parent must be reachable and able to respond immediately.
- Documented medical needs that require direct, reliable parental availability during school hours.
- Supports she currently has are being reframed — her documented needs characterized differently than the medical record supports.
- Support removals are being positioned as outcomes of 'progress' — without clinical grounding.

POLICY CONTRADICTION

- When a child's documented medical and developmental needs are administratively reframed as improvements, the consequence is not that the child needs less support. It is that the child receives less support — while the underlying need remains.
- This is cost reduction positioned as clinical determination. The government's own documentation of this pattern — across FSCD, PDD, and the school system — is available.
- A child whose supports are removed on the basis of reframed need is a child being set up for crisis. The cost of that crisis — medical, developmental, educational, or systemic — will be carried by the next government, the next program, and the next caseworker.
- This child is not being supported toward independence. Her documented needs are being minimized to reduce current program cost, while the downstream risk is transferred forward.

Section 3: The Structural Contradiction

These three children share more than a household and a diagnosis. They share a systemic position: they are all currently being failed by the government programs responsible for giving disabled children a foundation for adult life — while the government simultaneously designs an adult income program premised on those children eventually achieving employment and independence.

THE CONTRADICTION IN PLAIN LANGUAGE	
	The government is telling the current generation of disabled adults: you should be working toward independence.
	The government is simultaneously telling the next generation of disabled children — through its actions, not its words:
	• We cannot staff your classroom consistently.
	• We cannot provide timely children's disability services.
	• We cannot tell you when PDD will be available when you turn 18.
	• We will reframe your needs downward to reduce program cost.
	• We will cut the advocacy organizations that could help your family navigate the system.
	These two positions cannot coexist. The government is manufacturing the dependency it claims to be reducing.

3.1 The Pipeline the Government Has Built

Children with severe disabilities who do not receive adequate educational support do not develop greater independence. Children whose documented needs are reframed downward to reduce program cost do not receive fewer services because they need fewer — they receive fewer services while the underlying need compounds. Children who age out of FSCD into a PDD system with an unreported waitlist and 70% still not meeting their caseworker do not become independent adults. They become dependent adults in a system with fewer resources and no appeal rights.

The pipeline from inadequate childhood support to adult program dependency is not speculative. It is documented in the developmental literature and in Alberta's own downstream cost projections. The government is not preventing future reliance on disability income programs. It is guaranteeing it — and then designing that future program to provide less income and fewer protections than the current one.

STAGE	WHAT THE GOVERNMENT IS DOING
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Early childhood (FSCD)	3-year average wait for full services. 85% of families still without caseworker after partial services begin.
School age (Education system)	No consistent accountability framework for children too complex for standard supports. Contradictory documentation. Complaint processes as the only recourse.
Adolescence (Transition planning)	FSCD ends at 18. PDD application can begin at 16 — but service is not immediate. Waitlist duration unreported for 3 years.
Adulthood (PDD/AISH-ADAP)	70% of eligible adults have not met their PDD caseworker. AISH replaced by ADAP with reduced income, removed appeal rights, and employment-first framework applied regardless of capacity.
Throughout	Advocacy organizations that help families navigate these gaps had their funding cut in March 2026 — at the moment of highest demand.

Section 4: The Fiscal Argument

The government has framed the AISH-to-ADAP transition as a fiscal responsibility measure. The downstream costs of the systemic failures documented above are not being counted in that calculation.

COST ITEM	DOCUMENTED RANGE
Child welfare intervention (if family stability collapses)	\$80,000 to \$250,000+ per child per year in government care
Delayed educational milestones	Increased Special Education costs throughout K-12; documented as a downstream outcome of poverty and instability
Psychiatric crisis intervention (ED visit)	\$1,000 to \$3,000+ per visit; Alberta ED psychiatric visits up 47% prior to ADAP transition
Adult program dependency (PDD/ADAP)	Compounds existing program costs with reduced capacity for supported independence
Net saving from AISH-to-ADAP transition (before downstream costs)	\$27 million — after \$22 million in administration overhead
Alberta Heritage Fund growth (Q3 2025-26 alone)	\$383 million

THE FISCAL REALITY
The government is saving \$27 million net from the AISH-to-ADAP transition — before any downstream costs are counted.

The documented downstream costs of failing to support the next generation of disabled children adequately include child welfare intervention, educational remediation, psychiatric crisis response, and compounded adult program dependency — all of which cost more than the program it is replacing.

This is not a savings. It is a cost transfer — from the disability income budget to every other budget the government manages.

Section 5: The Policy Cannot Have It Both Ways

If the government's position is that disability income support should be redesigned around employment and independence as goals, then the government must also ensure that the systems responsible for building the capacity for independence are adequately resourced, consistently staffed, and held to account.

It has not done this. The same ministry that administers AISH, FSCD, and PDD has applied hiring freezes across all three simultaneously. The same minister responsible for ADAP is responsible for a children's disability services system with a three-year average wait and an unreported adult transition waitlist. The same budget that cuts \$49 million from AISH has produced nominal increases to FSCD and PDD that are below the population-plus-inflation benchmark — meaning real cuts, despite the numbers.

A government that is genuinely building toward independence for disabled Albertans does not simultaneously dismantle every system that makes independence possible for the next generation of disabled Albertans.

A government that does both — that mandates employment-readiness in the adult income program while failing education, children's disability services, transition planning, and the advocacy sector simultaneously — is not reducing dependency. It is producing it. It is simply deferring the cost to the next fiscal cycle, the next government, and the next generation.

CONCLUSION

The AISH-to-ADAP transition cannot be assessed in isolation.

It must be assessed against the full policy environment in which it operates: an environment in which the children of AISH recipients are currently being failed by the school system, waiting years for children's disability services, facing an undisclosed transition waitlist into adult disability programs, and watching the advocacy organizations that could help their families navigate these gaps have their funding cut.

The government cannot have it both ways.

It cannot mandate independence as a policy goal for disabled adults while guaranteeing dependency as a policy outcome for disabled children.

This is not a political argument. It is a structural one.

The contradiction is built into the policy. And the next generation will inherit the consequences.

*This document is part of the Alberta Disability Income Reform Series, April 2026.
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SOURCE INDEX

All documented claims in *The Intergenerational Contradiction* trace to the documentary base below. Where a source has already been documented in *The Compound Failure Brief* (April 2026, 69 pages) or the *Information Asymmetry Report* (April 2026, 49 pages), this index references the prior documentation rather than duplicating it.

GOVERNMENT OF ALBERTA — PROGRAMS, LEGISLATION, BUDGETS

Government of Alberta — ADAP Program Page and Discussion Guide. Official Alberta Disability Assistance Program documentation establishing the July 1, 2026 effective date for the AISH-to-ADAP transition; the \$1,740/month base benefit; the \$200/month transition top-up effective through December 31, 2027; and the program's stated employment-first framework. alberta.ca.

Government of Alberta — Bill 12 (Disability Assistance Programs Amendment Act). Passed December 9, 2025. Eliminates appeal of AISH-to-ADAP transition decisions; replaces the independent Citizens Appeal Panel with the government-appointed Medical Review Panel; removes appeal of medical-eligibility determinations to any independent body. assembly.ab.ca. Independent legal analysis: Zachary Weeks, November 28, 2025; CBC News reporting, August 21, 2025.

Government of Alberta — Budget 2025. AISH funding 2025-26: \$1.641 billion, a \$49 million reduction from prior year. Projected further reductions: \$22 million (2026-27), \$6 million (2027-28). Total projected three-year program reduction: \$77 million. FSCD budget increase: 3.61% — below the 7.3% population-plus-inflation benchmark, producing a real-terms cut of -3.69%. PDD budget increase: 5.94% — also below the 7.3% benchmark, producing a real-terms cut of -1.36%. alberta.ca / Treasury Board and Finance.

Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund — Q3 2025-26 Report. Fund fair value \$31.9 billion as of December 31, 2025. Q3 2025-26 growth: \$383 million in a single quarter. Fiscal year-to-date return: 7.7%. alberta.ca/heritage-savings-trust-fund.

Standing Committee on the Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund — 2024-25 Annual Report. Market value \$27.2 billion as of March 31, 2025; five-year annualized return 9.6%. assembly.ab.ca.

Government of Alberta — Disability Advocacy Funding Decisions, March 2026. Funding cuts to three disability advocacy organizations announced March 2026, ending support twelve months earlier than the previously communicated end date. Inclusion Alberta funding reduced by \$500,000. Documented in CBC News reporting and in the *Compound Failure Brief* — Pillar IV.

INCLUSION ALBERTA — SURVEY DATA

Inclusion Alberta — "Experiences with Family Support for Children with Disabilities" (FSCD Survey Report). January 2025. 540 respondents across 79 of 87 Alberta provincial electoral districts, surveyed October-November 2024. Three-year average wait for full FSCD services. 85% of families receiving Family Support Services still without an assigned caseworker after partial services begin. 58% of families reporting negative effects from going without supports — including job loss, missed developmental windows, and physical and mental health deterioration. inclusionalberta.org.

Inclusion Alberta / ALIGN — "PDD Current State: Critical and Urgent." January 2025. 540 PDD-connected respondents. 70% of eligible adults still needing to meet their caseworker to develop an outcome plan. 41% of respondents reporting that supports they eventually receive are not helping. The survey was conducted because the Government of Alberta has not published PDD waitlist data since 2021 — a three-year reporting gap. inclusionalberta.org / alignab.ca.

CLINICAL AND DIAGNOSTIC FRAMEWORKS

American Psychiatric Association — Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition (DSM-5), Text Revision (DSM-5-TR). 2022. Establishes the three-level severity classification for Autism Spectrum Disorder. Level 3 — "Requiring very substantial support" — is the most severe classification within the diagnostic framework. psychiatry.org.

INDEPENDENT REPORTING AND ANALYSIS

Alberta Doctors' Digest — "Pushing back against changes that make life harder for disabled Albertans." November/December 2025. Documents the 47% increase in Alberta Emergency Department visits for psychiatric crises in the period preceding the ADAP transition. albertadoctors.org.

FACTSMTR Substack — "Alberta Budget 2026: Testing the \$9.4B Claim." February 28, 2026. Documents the \$22 million ADAP administrative restructuring overhead, the \$1.2 billion/year forgone revenue from the 8% income tax bracket cut, and Alberta's deficit projections. factsmtr.substack.com.

CBC News — "Provincial support delays are hurting disabled Albertans and families, reports find." Bellefontaine, M. January 23, 2025. Documents the FSCD backlog of over 7,000 children and the lived experience of families navigating multi-year waits for children's disability services. cbc.ca.

Hold My Hand Alberta — Caseworker Caseload Documentation. September 2024. Documents one FSCD caseworker carrying over 400 families against a recommended maximum of 100. holdmyhandalberta.com.

CHILD WELFARE COST REFERENCES

Government of Canada — Indigenous Services Canada and provincial child welfare cost reporting. Per-child-per-year costs of children-in-care intervention documented across published provincial accounting and federal child welfare cost-of-care literature, with the \$80,000 to \$250,000+ range reflecting variation by placement type (kinship, foster, group home, treatment-level care). Cited as a downstream cost reference, not as a prediction of any individual family's trajectory.

INTERNAL CROSS-REFERENCES — CAMPAIGN DOCUMENTARY BASE

The Compound Failure Brief. The Alberta Disability System Breakdown, April 2026. 69 pages. Pillar III (Children's Services Failure) documents the FSCD/PDD architecture, the three-stage access system, and the Citizens Appeal Panel performance record cited above. Pillar IV (Rights Failure) documents Bill 12 and the appeal-rights restructuring. albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app.

Information Asymmetry Report. The Alberta Disability System Breakdown, April 2026. 49 pages. Documents the structural information failure across each transition point in Alberta's disability system. Plain Language Companion (12 pages) available alongside. [albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app](#).

The Heritage Fund and AISH: What the Government's Own Numbers Show. ADSB April 2026 Report Series. Side-by-side documentation of Heritage Fund growth against simultaneous AISH cuts. The "Heritage Fund grew five times the total three-year AISH cut in a single three-month period" comparison cited in this report originates here.

Financial Reality Report (Document 1 of the ADSB Report Series). April 2026. Documents the AISH and ADAP benefit amounts, the Canada Disability Benefit clawback structure, and the cost-of-living gap. [albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app](#).

HOUSEHOLD DOCUMENTARY RECORD (GENERALIZED)

Active complaint filed with the Alberta Teaching Profession Commission (ATPC). The household referenced in Section 2 has an active ATPC complaint with seven grounds and a thirty-two-entry evidence index, filed against the school principal. The complaint, supporting documentation, school correspondence, and timestamped record are retained by the household. Specific identifying details are not reproduced in this report; the documentary record exists and is available to investigative bodies on request.

Methodology note. The three child profiles presented in Section 2 are documented profiles of three children in a single Alberta household, presented without identifying information, drawn from the household's own clinical, educational, and complaint record. They are not hypothetical and not composite. They are documented circumstances of a single family, generalized only to remove identification.

The fiscal calculations in Section 4 are derived from the Government of Alberta's own Budget 2025 figures, the Heritage Fund and Q3 2025-26 Report, and the FACTSMTR analysis of Budget 2026, applied through arithmetic the reader can independently verify.